

Engineering College Cheat Sheet

Score any college in under 10 minutes · Compare three options side by side · Let the data — not the brochure — decide

Step 1. Fill Part A (parents) or Part B (student) for each college you're considering. **Step 2.** Fill Part C for each branch-college combo on your shortlist. **Step 3.** Add college score + best branch score in Part D. **Step 4.** Highest total wins. Tie? Branch score breaks it.

KEY FORMULAS — Calculate These Before Any Campus Visit

Fill Rate	Total students admitted ÷ AICTE-sanctioned intake × 100
Placement %	Students placed ÷ Total students enrolled × 100 (not just placement-registered)
Idle Output Index	(Total enrolled – Placed – Higher Studies) ÷ Total enrolled × 100
Median Salary	Middle salary from NIRF data — ignore the highest figure in the brochure

PART A — Parent Scorecard (10 Points)

Four data points every parent should check — all available on the NIRF dashboard.

Criterion	Max	0 pts	1 pt	2 pts	3 pts
Fill Rate	3	≤60%	61–70%	71–85%	>85%
Placement %	2	≤65%	65–80%	>80%	—
Median Salary	3	≤5 LPA	5–6 LPA	6–8 LPA	>8 LPA
Idle Output Index	2	>40%	21–40%	≤20%	—

Criterion	College 1	College 2	College 3
Fill Rate (/3)			
Placement % (/2)			
Median Salary (/3)			
Idle Output Index (/2)			
Total			

Total Part A: _____ / 10

PART B — Student Scorecard (15 Points) · Use if student visits campus

Same four criteria as Part A, plus **Campus Vibe /5** scored by the student. Vibe scoring: 0 = no impression · 1–2 = it was okay · 3–4 = felt good · 5 = loved it

Criterion	College 1	College 2	College 3
Fill Rate (/3)			
Placement % (/2)			
Median Salary (/3)			
Idle Output Index (/2)			
Campus Vibe (/5)			
Total			

Total Part B: _____ / 15

PART C — Branch Scorecard (10 Points)

Score the specific branch you are considering at each college. Fill in up to four combinations.

Criterion	Max	0 pts	1 pt	2 pts	3 pts	4 pts
Branch Placement %	3	≤60%	61–80%	80–90%	>90%	—
COEs for Branch	3	0	1	2	≥3	—
6-Month+ Internships	4	≤50%	—	51–70%	—	>70%

Criterion	Option 1	Option 2	Option 3	Option 4
Branch Placement % (/3)				
COEs for Branch (/3)				
6-Month+ Internships (/4)				
Total				

Total Part C: _____ / 10

PART D — Final Combined Score

Add college score (Part A or B) + best branch score (Part C). Use the same part for all three colleges.

Criterion	College 1	College 2	College 3
College Score — Parent (/10)			
Best Branch Score (/10)			
Parent Total (/20)			
College Score — Student (/15)			
Best Branch Score (/10)			
Student Total (/25)			
Final Rank			

QUICK TIPS

Fill Rate

Use AICTE-sanctioned intake — not today's class size. Quiet reductions hide poor demand.

Placement %

Ask: placed out of how many total? Include everyone enrolled, not just placement-registered students.

Idle Output Index

Above 30% = serious red flag. Below 20% = healthy. This number never appears in any brochure.

COEs

A Centre of Excellence for your branch = real investment. A name on a door means nothing.

Campus Vibe

Walk up to random students in the canteen. The college arranged some tours — talk to the others.

Tie-breaker

Same score on two colleges? The stronger branch score wins. That's closer to your actual career.

The Numbers Behind the Decision

Three tables that tell you what the brochure never will. Check all three before signing the admission form.

TABLE 1 — Fees to Justified Salary

What annual salary justifies the fees? Based on recovering total 4-year cost within 2 years of starting work. **Rule:** if the college's NIRF median salary is below this number — walk away.

Annual Fee	4-Year Total Cost	Min. Justified Salary
■50,000	■2,00,000	■3,50,000
■1,00,000	■4,00,000	■4,50,000
■1,50,000	■6,00,000	■5,50,000
■2,00,000	■8,00,000	■4,00,000
■2,50,000	■10,00,000	■5,00,000
■3,00,000	■12,00,000	■6,00,000
■5,00,000	■20,00,000	■10,00,000

TABLE 2 — Monthly Take-Home Reality Check

Tax is ■0 for CTC up to ■12L (Section 87A rebate, new regime FY2025-26). Cost of living minimum: ■20,000/month. **Highlighted row = ■12L breakeven point.**

Annual CTC	Monthly Gross	Tax /mo.	Take-Home	Cost of Living	Surplus /mo.
■3.5L	■29,167	■0	■29,167	■20,000	■9,167
■4L	■33,333	■0	■33,333	■20,000	■13,333
■5L	■41,667	■0	■41,667	■21,000	■20,667
■6L	■50,000	■0	■50,000	■22,000	■28,000
■8L	■66,667	■0	■66,667	■23,000	■43,667
■10L	■83,333	■0	■83,333	■25,000	■58,333
■12L	■1,00,000	■0	■1,00,000	■28,000	■72,000
■15L	■1,25,000	■8,750	■1,16,250	■35,000	■81,250
■18L	■1,50,000	■13,333	■1,36,667	■42,000	■94,667
■20L	■1,66,667	■16,667	■1,50,000	■48,000	■1,02,000
■25L	■2,08,333	■27,500	■1,80,833	■58,000	■1,22,833

Above ■12L: tax at 15% (■12–16L), 20% (■16–20L), 25% (■20–24L), 30% (>■24L) — new income tax regime.

TABLE 3 — Education Loan Reality Check

12% annual interest, compounded monthly. 4-year moratorium (course + 6 months). 5-year repayment. **Highlighted row = ■3L/yr — the most common private college fee tier.**

Annual Fee	Borrowed	Balance After 4 Yrs	Monthly EMI	Total Repaid	Interest Paid
■50K/yr	■2,00,000	■3,22,445	■7,173	■4,30,380	■2,30,380
■1L/yr	■4,00,000	■6,44,890	■14,345	■8,60,700	■4,60,700
■1.5L/yr	■6,00,000	■9,67,336	■21,518	■12,91,080	■6,91,080
■2L/yr	■8,00,000	■12,89,781	■28,690	■17,21,400	■9,21,400
■2.5L/yr	■10,00,000	■16,12,226	■35,863	■21,51,780	■11,51,780
■3L/yr	■12,00,000	■19,34,671	■43,036	■25,82,160	■13,82,160
■5L/yr	■20,00,000	■32,24,452	■71,726	■43,03,560	■23,03,560

At ■3L/yr: you borrow ■12L, but by the time you start repaying, you owe ■19.3L. Your EMI is ■43,036/month for 5 years. Check if the college's median NIRF salary can sustain this.

This cheat sheet is from **How Not to Choose Your College — Engineering Edition**
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